

Qi to the Bone Marrow

洗髓功 *Xǐ Suǐ Gōng*

ORIGINS

Bone Marrow Washing belongs to one of the older and more esoteric branches of qigong, traditionally associated with the legendary transmission of Bodhidharma and practised in various forms across Buddhist and Daoist internal traditions. This version has been developed and refined through years of direct teaching, close in spirit to that lineage but very much its own sequence.

WHAT IT IS FOR

The practice moves through four distinct phases — opening, contraction, expansion, and the marrow fill itself — before drawing a vast field of heavenly qi down through the crown and into the bones directly, region by region. Where most qigong works the organs or the flesh, this one works the marrow: the deepest, most hidden layer of the body.

1 Opening — Om, Ah, Hum *gathering light above the head, drawing it down through three centres*

1	Stance Stand with feet shoulder-width apart.
2	Gather the Light The hands rise to the sides of the body and then overhead, as though holding a ball of light above the head.
3	Draw It Down Through Three Centres Bring the hands into prayer position and draw the light down in three stages, chanting as each centre is reached: " Om " at the third eye, " Ah " at the throat, " Hum " at the heart. This opens the practice.
4	Release The hands carry naturally down and release, coming to rest at the sides of the body.

2 The Smallest Point in the Universe *contraction, and the keystone hand position*

1	The Keystone Position The hands rise again to heart level in prayer position, but held away from the body, so that the heels of the hands work like the keystone of a bridge — the structure supporting itself, resting at heart level with no effort required to hold it there.
2	Contract to a Single Point Close the eyes. Feel as though you are the smallest possible thing in the universe — the whole universe shrunk down to a single point, which is you.
3	Hold Hold this posture and this feeling for some minutes.
4	Release The hands move down, the eyes open, and the arms come to rest at the sides of the body.

3 Filling the Universe *expansion, open pores, and the wide gaze*

1	Palms Forward, Arms to Shoulder Height Turn the palms forward, then raise the arms to shoulder level.
2	Turn the Palms to the Sides Turn the heel of the hand outward so the palms face out to the sides. The elbows are never straight or locked — hold a slight bend throughout, an outward extension without ever fully straightening the arms.
3	Become the Size of the Universe Open the eyes wide. Imagine you are filling the universe in every direction — your hands touch its outer edges, your head touches its "top," your feet its "bottom." Imagine your hair grown long, wild, and flowing, and every pore of the body wide open, as the universe flows through you and around you.
4	Release Relax the eyes, and relax the arms back down to the sides of the body.

4 The Marrow Fill — White Mist *drawing heavenly qi down through the crown and into the bones, region by region*

1	Right Kidney, Left Hand Bring the back of the left hand to rest against the right kidney.
2	Right Arm Rises Overhead The right palm faces forward, rises out to the side, and continues up and over until the back of the hand is above the crown.
3	Gentle Press, Not a Stretch Gently press upward so the tendons of the arm activate — the arm is never fully straight. You press, and the arm naturally finds its correct position; the movement itself is small, perhaps thirty centimetres.
4	The Field of Purple Qi Above the head, imagine a vast field of purple qi — heavenly qi, yang qi.
5	Sense and Mix Turn the right palm to face the crown. Feel your own energy through the <i>lao gong</i> point at the centre of the palm. Mix the purple qi of the heavens with your own energy, where together they form a whitish, pearlescent mist.
6	Draw the Mist Down Through the Bones Draw the right hand slowly down the front of the body, palm facing down, drawing this pearlescent mist into the bones as the hand passes each region in turn: the bones of the head and face, the neck and shoulders, the ribs and upper arms, the spine and lower arms, the pelvis, the bones of the upper legs, and finally the bones of the lower legs and feet. As the hand moves, the bones in that region fill with the mist. The hand's physical journey usually finishes before the visualisation catches up — move the hand slowly, and let the energy-mist move a little faster, so that the filling completes fully by the time the hand reaches the feet.
7	Repeat, Left Side Repeat the full sequence on the left side: back of the right hand at the left kidney, left arm rising overhead, left palm gathering and mixing the purple qi, left hand drawing the mist down through the bones.
8	Repeat, Both Arms Together Finally, repeat the sequence once more with both arms rising and drawing the mist down together, filling the whole skeleton at once.

PRACTICE NOTES

- The pace throughout is slow and unforced — particularly in Phase 4, where the hand's movement and the visualisation's movement are deliberately allowed to run at slightly different speeds, resolving together only at the feet.
- Phase 2's "smallest point" and Phase 3's "size of the universe" are a deliberate pair — full contraction followed by full expansion — and should not be rushed past on the way to the marrow fill.
- The thirty-centimetre press in Phase 4 is a small, tendon-activating movement, not a stretch to full extension — the arm finds its own correct position rather than being forced there.

SEQUENCE AT A GLANCE

1. Opening — Om at the third eye, Ah at the throat, Hum at the heart. **2. Contraction** — the keystone hands, and the smallest point in the universe. **3. Expansion** — palms to the sides, pores open, filling the universe. **4. Marrow Fill** — purple qi drawn from above the crown, mixed at the lao gong into a white mist, and that mist drawn down through the bones: right side, then left, then both together.

